

LIFE OF A COURTESAN
(From left) A scene from *Heeramandi*; Richa Chadha



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MONIKA SHERGILL

arcs. "It is so demanding, so difficult, you have to be so alert because there are so many tracks and your narrative skills get sharpened," said Bhansali. For a change, he also found himself working with producers who came with thoughts and notes on writing for a new format and also insights on what works in a burgeoning industry. Describing his meetings with Shergill and Tanya Bami, Netflix's series head, Bhansali had said with a teasing smile: "They are very difficult to handle... You have to be ready to go through the grind because they are very demanding... We've fought amongst ourselves."

Shergill has a different take on those meetings. "They are not boring, they are electric," she told INDIA TODAY. "He has a great sense of humour and drama, there's a lot of amazing fun banter." Having worked with the likes of Imtiaz Ali, Vishal Bhardwaj and Zoya Akhtar at Netflix, Shergill speaks of how "it's not easy" to work with Bhansali, a filmmaker "who's a master of every single department" and constantly "chasing perfection".

"All geniuses have unique quirks and he does too," she notes. "He is exacting on his artistes and on himself. He knows his audience for his brand of cinema. Our job is to tell him that it has to adapt to streaming first...It felt great being on the other side and having relief wash over me because he will make it better than your wildest dreams." One exception that Netflix India has already made for *Heeramandi* is in carrying Bhansali's name upfront in the promotions.

Exporting Indian Culture

For many, *Heeramandi* has the potential to be the Netflix India original that finds international resonance, like Mexico's *Narcos*, South Korea's *Squid Game*, Spain's *Money Heist* and Germany's *Dark* did. At the trailer launch Richa Chadha echoed the sentiment. In an interview to INDIA TODAY magazine, she had said, "Countries like India and China, which have years of civilisations, when they make a historical drama with an anti-imperialist theme and characters who are fighting for independence from patriarchy and to make [their] own choices.... it can travel outside India." She cited the examples of Hong Kong's *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon* and *Memoirs of a Geisha* (which though a Hollywood film, had a Japanese cast and also used the language) as films that struck a chord in the West.

Heeramandi is Chadha's second collaboration with Bhansali and one that allows her to break the mould. Chadha plays Lajjo, a courtesan who she described as a woman "soaked in tragedy and one who has started enjoying her own haplessness". The actress is familiar with the legends associated with Bhansali—taskmaster, difficult, demanding on set—but for her he is the rare "aesthete" who intersperses classical performing arts into his mainstream spectacles. This explains the fact that one of Bhansali's first creations for *Heeramandi* was composing a *thumri*. "He gives it so much space and respect that he makes it accessible," says Chadha. I know that may be [the reason] why most people want to work with him again is that he makes everyone look beautiful but, for me, when I find someone whom I can jam with on culture, I get tremendously excited and it inspires me."

It remains to be seen whether Bhansali's cultural feast captivates Netflix subscribers worldwide or wins an International Emmy like the Netflix drama *Delhi Crime* did. Costume period dramas have been mostly miss affairs in Indian streaming (*The Empire*, *Taj–Divided by Blood*) but, for Shergill, *Heeramandi* is a bet worth taking, even if it is expensive and time-consuming. "When you don't have box office pressure, you appreciate art for what it is," she says. "The day we became formulaic in streaming, it will be the end of us." ■